

Pre-Planning Guide

Planning ahead means your family doesn't have to make dozens of decisions during the worst week of their lives. It also locks in today's pricing.

SECTION 1

Why Pre-Plan?

Taking the pressure off the people you love

When a death happens unexpectedly, families face **dozens of decisions** in a matter of days — often while grieving, exhausted, and under financial pressure. Pre-planning lets you make those choices **on your own terms**, with time to think, compare, and discuss.

Pre-planning is not just about your own preferences. It's about the people you'll leave behind, and it takes away the guessing.

A pre-plan can be as simple or detailed as you'd like. You can plan the big decisions (cremation or burial, where to be placed) and leave the smaller ones to your family, or you can specify every detail down to the flowers and music.

SECTION 2

Decisions to Make

The choices families face — and the ones you can make in advance

There are **more decisions than most people realize**. Pre-planning lets you work through them at your own pace, rather than all at once under pressure.

Cremation or Burial?

The most fundamental choice. Each opens different options for services, caskets, and final resting place.

Where to Rest?

Cemetery section, columbarium niche, urn garden, scattering garden, or another location entirely.

Type of Service?

Traditional funeral with viewing, memorial service, graveside service, celebration of life, or private family gathering.

Casket or Urn?

Over 200 caskets and 248 urns to choose from — or let your family decide from your shortlist.

Marker or Monument?

Flush granite marker, bronze marker, or upright monument (where permitted). Color, size, inscription.

Photo Portrait?

Ceramic steel photo on the marker? Diamond etching? Which photo to use?

Obituary & Records

How many death certificates? Who to notify? What should the obituary say?

Personal Touches

Flowers, music, readings, pallbearers, charitable donations in lieu of flowers.

SECTION 3

How It Works

Pre-planning is simpler than you think

1

Meet with Us

A free, no-pressure conversation at the cemetery, in your home, or by phone. We'll walk through your options and answer every question.

2

Make Your Selections

Choose your services, resting place, casket or urn, and marker. Take your time — there's no deadline and no rush.

3

Put It in Writing

We document everything and provide your family with a copy. When the time comes, we handle everything exactly as you planned.

No Obligation, No Pressure

A pre-planning consultation is **completely free**. You're welcome to meet once, take months to decide, and come back when you're ready. Many families start with a simple conversation and return later to finalize details.

There is no cost to file your wishes with us, and no obligation to prepay. Writing down what you want and leaving it on file is a service, not a purchase. Prepaying is a separate decision, and it is entirely yours to make later or not at all.

You can also make changes to your pre-plan at any time. Life changes, and your plan can change with it.

SECTION 4

Cremation & Burial Options

A brief overview of the two primary paths

Your pre-plan starts with one fundamental question: **cremation or burial?** Both are available at Washington Memorial Park, and both can include a full range of services.

Cremation Plans

Direct cremation — simplest and most affordable. No service, remains returned to family.

Cremation with memorial — cremation first, followed by a memorial service at a later date.

Cremation with viewing — a traditional viewing or funeral before cremation takes place.

Burial Plans

Traditional burial — viewing, funeral service, and interment at the cemetery.

Graveside service — a service held at the graveside, often simpler and more intimate.

Entombment — above-ground placement in a mausoleum (limited availability).

Each path includes choices about **services, merchandise, and cemetery property**. We'll walk you through every option and build a quote so you can see the full picture before committing to anything.

SECTION 5

Financial Benefits

Pre-planning protects against rising costs

Lock In Today's Prices

Cemetery property, services, and merchandise prices increase over time. A pre-plan purchased today is honored at today's prices, regardless of when it is needed.

Flexible Payment Options

Pay in full or set up a payment plan that fits your budget. No interest on cemetery property payments.

Asset Protection

Pre-paid funeral and cemetery arrangements may be exempt from Medicaid spend-down requirements in Washington state. Consult your attorney or financial advisor for specifics.

No Financial Burden on Family

Your family won't face a large, unexpected expense during an already difficult time. Everything is taken care of.

SECTION 6

Common Questions

What families ask most about pre-planning

Is pre-planning the same as pre-paying?

No. You can pre-plan (make selections and document your wishes) without paying anything upfront. Pre-paying is optional and locks in pricing.

Can I change my pre-plan later?

Yes. Life circumstances change, and your plan can change with them. Contact us to make adjustments at any time.

What if I move out of the area?

Cemetery property at Washington Memorial Park is yours regardless of where you live. Funeral service arrangements can be transferred or adjusted.

Do I need to decide everything right now?

Not at all. Many families start with the big decisions (cremation or burial, location) and fill in details over time. Any amount of planning helps.

How do I get started?

Call or email us for a free, no-pressure conversation. We can meet at the cemetery, at your home, or by phone.



Serving Seattle families since 1868 · Washington Memorial Park

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